

No More Googling, Says Google

In a kind of stupid decision, Google intends to crack down on the use of its name as a generic verb. One would think that the use of the word "googling" could only bolster Google's image, but Google says the phrase is potentially damaging to its brand.



Gigabytes For Golf

Samsung has unveiled a "golf phone." It comes with 8 GB of storage, and incorporates the information one needs, to play demanding golf courses! There's a GPS receiver, which is used to work out how far one is from the green, and to suggest appropriate clubbage.



Escape

TOO MUCH MONEY

A Picture For Your Thoughts

Here's the official News-Of-Useless-Research-In-Developed-Countries department in this space. This time, it's about art. (A couple of months ago, it was about music.) Computer art that changes according to your mood. Allow us to explain.

British and American computer scientists have developed computer art that changes according to how the viewer feels. It's a Webcam setup: software picks up facial cues from the Webcam image, and adjusts the colours and brush strokes of the digital image.

"The program analyses the image of eight facial expressions... to work out the emotional state of the viewer," said Dr John Collomosse of the University of Bath in England. "It does this in real-time, meaning that as the viewer's

emotions change, the artwork responds accordingly."

So basically, you're sitting at this computer with a Webcam. You're seeing "art" on the monitor. You frown, and you get dark, sombre artwork. You smile, and you get a bright, flowery image.

Question: What precisely are the practical applications of the system?

And that's why we included this bit of news here—to highlight the fact that there's more and more of such useless tech research going on. Give us some of your money, for God's sake, and let us develop a malaria vaccine!

Top three reasons we aren't impressed:

#1. You already have pictures in your head when you're in different moods. Why the picture on the screen?

#2. All this seems just a hash-up of face-recognition software and Winamp visualisations.

#3. You'd look at art to get an impression of what was in the artist's head, not what's in yours.

CROSSING THE LINE

All Pods Are iPods

A small, family-owned company called Mach 5 Products makes electronic devices. One of them is "an infrared data collection system for arcade games, vending machines, and anything else that you need accurate and easy data collection." Up until now, the only way to figure how much money an arcade game took in, and how many prizes or tickets it gave out,

Whatever Happened To...

PNG?

PNG, though it's there, isn't a very popular image file format on the Web today. Portable Network Graphics is a bitmap image format that employs lossless compression; it was created to improve upon and replace GIF, which had a patent attached to it, and (probably) TIFF.

It's all a story about patents. The LZW compression algorithm—which forms the basis for GIF—was covered by a US patent owned by Unisys Corporation. When CompuServe developed the GIF format, they weren't even aware that LZW was covered by a patent! And in 1994, Unisys discovered that the newly-popular GIF used LZW, and announced they would be seeking royalties on that patent. By that time, GIF was so widespread that most companies using it just had to pony up. And this was mainly why PNG was developed.

Then in 2003, the US patent on the LZW algorithm expired, which meant that royalties could no longer be collected for use of GIF in the United States. The same happened in other countries soon afterwards.

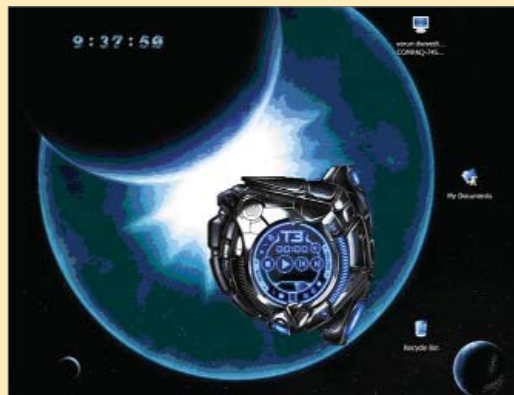
PNG was, naturally, left in the lurch: why shift to PNG when you could go ahead and use GIF without paying a royalty? Well, there do exist some reasons, such as its ability to make images partially transparent, and to exceed 256 colors—neither of which GIF can do. But that wasn't enough to really make it replace GIF, and PNG remains a shadowy presence.

Win! My Desktop

Last month's winner is Varun Kumar Dwivedi, Varanasi. His spaced out desktop comes from interesting use of ObjectDock and DesktopX widgets. He used:
Chameleon clock 3.5 for clock
Icon 1.10 for the desktop icons
Hide window now v2.5 to hide the taskbar
Congratulations!

Participate in this contest and win next month

Amkette Multimedia Office Keyboard



Send your desktop with description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject 'My Desktop'; and tell us your postal address, too.